

TEXT OF OPENING REMARKS BY

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CHAIRMAN, BOARD OF TRUSTEES (BoT)

**PRESENTED AT THE MAIDEN JOINT MEETING OF THE BOARD OF TRUSTEES (BoT)
AND EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE MEMBERS OF THE PEOPLES ASSEMBLY OF
NORTHERN KADUNA INITIATIVE FOR PEACE AND HARMONY, HELD AT AREWA
HOUSE, KADUNA, ON TUESDAY, 3RD FEBRUARY, 2026**

Protocol.

It gives me great pleasure to warmly welcome members of the Board of Trustees (BoT) and members of the Executive Committee of the People's Assembly of Northern Kaduna Initiative for Peace and Harmony to this maiden and historic joint meeting.

Let me begin by congratulating all of us on the successful registration of the Assembly with the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC). This achievement did not come easy, as we were required to change the name of the organisation several times to meet CAC requirements. The process demanded time, financial resources, and above all, the ingenuity and perseverance of our legal team, to whom we are deeply grateful.

We sincerely appreciate your individual and collective prayers, support, and words of encouragement that have brought us to where we are today. This meeting has therefore been convened to formally intimate members of the successful registration of the People's Assembly (hereinafter referred to as "the Assembly").

This Opening Remarks will be incomplete without reminding ourselves of the common factors that bind us together and led to the establishment of the Assembly. Among the major components are the following:

- (1) As members of the Assembly, we share a common geographical space within Kaduna State, politically identified as Zones One and Two of the three Senatorial Districts of the State. More importantly, we are united by a homogeneity of culture, religion, language, traditional emirate system, and a shared history dating back many centuries.

Historically, our shared heritage dates back to the establishment of the Zazzau Kingdom during the reign of Sarki Gunguma of the Habe dynasty, through the Fulani Jihad of 1804, which integrated the area into the Sokoto Caliphate. Mallam Musa Bamalli, founder of the Mallawa Ruling House, emerged as the first Emir of Zazzau after receiving the Flag from the renowned 18th-century Islamic reformer and revivalist, Sheikh Usmanu Dan Fodio (1754–1817). Consequently, Zazzau became one of the fourteen (14) original flag-bearing emirates established to revive Islam in the region.

At its peak, the Zazzau Emirate extended over present-day Doma, Jama'a, the entire Southern Kaduna chiefdoms, Keffi, Lafiya Bare-Bari, Lapai, Nasarawa to the south; Saminaka and Lere to the east; Birnin Gwari to the west; and Paki to the north. Following several administrative realignments over the years, the Emirate today comprises eleven (11) Local Government Areas within Kaduna State, with Birnin Gwari included for the purpose of this Assembly.

- (2) The area under the jurisdiction of the Assembly hosts major urban centres such as Kaduna, the present capital of Kaduna State; the former capital of the defunct North-Central State (now Kaduna and Katsina States); and the former capital of the Northern Region of Nigeria, which now comprises nineteen (19) Northern States and the Federal Capital Territory (FCT). Zaria, the headquarters of the Zazzau Emirate, is also within this axis.

The Kaduna–Jaji–Zaria corridor represents one of the areas in Nigeria with the highest concentration of military institutions, educational institutions, and population density. Indeed, in terms of the density of such facilities per square kilometre, few areas compare, except perhaps Abuja and Lagos. This

concentration represents a significant asset that must be strategically harnessed for the benefit of our people.

- (3) The Assembly's jurisdiction is home to Nigerians from all parts of the country who have settled here and continue to live in harmony with the host communities. This diversity remains a major source of strength for the Assembly.
- (4) In terms of transportation, Birnin Gwari, Saminaka, Kaduna, and Zaria serve as major gateways into core Northern Nigeria. The volume of vehicular movement through these corridors on a 24-hour basis is of immense economic value. Any disruption along these routes negatively affects the entire Northern region, particularly the North-West and North-East zones.
- (5) Agriculturally, the area within the Assembly is endowed with fertile arable land and high agricultural output. It is notable for vegetable production in Giwa, Kudan, Makarfi, and Ikara LGAs; grains such as guinea corn, maize, and millet in Giwa, Lere, Kubau, Soba, Zaria, and Igabi LGAs; and tubers including yam, sweet potatoes, cocoyam, and Irish potatoes in Igabi, Zaria, Kubau, and Saminaka LGAs.

Cash crops such as ginger, hibiscus, moringa, sugarcane, pepper, and chilli are grown abundantly across the LGAs. Livestock rearing—including cattle, sheep, goats, poultry, guinea fowl—and fisheries also thrive throughout the area. The combination of the rainy season (May to October) and irrigation farming ensures year-round agricultural engagement.

- (6) In terms of solid minerals, Birnin Gwari LGA stands out prominently. Significant deposits of lithium, kaolin, gold, and other minerals are also found in parts of Giwa, Kubau, and Ikara LGAs.
- (7) Unfortunately, industrial manufacturing for local consumption and export has declined significantly since the mid-1980s. This decline is attributable to inadequate electricity supply, energy challenges, divestment, an unpredictable investment climate, and the weakening of the Naira against major international currencies.

The foregoing highlights some of the major assets and challenges affecting the area of the Assembly. It is therefore evident that the Assembly could not have been established at a more appropriate time than now.

Members will observe that politics has been deliberately excluded from this discourse. This is because the Assembly is non-political in nature. Our objective is to pursue development and collective progress through peaceful and constitutionally acceptable engagement with State and Federal Governments.

With these few remarks, I once again warmly welcome members of the Board of Trustees and the Executive Committee to this maiden joint meeting.

May Allah (SWT) continue to guide and protect our communities, our State, and our nation. *Amin.*

Thank you very much for your rapt attention.